

June 30 Justice Liberhan Commission submits its report on the Babri Masjid demolition.

July 2 Delhi High Court ruling decriminalises gay sex in India.

July 17 The Nano delivered to its first customer.

Aug 17 Jaswant Singh's new book, *Jinnah: India, Partition, Independence* released.

Aug 19 BJP expels Jaswant Singh from its primary membership.

Sept 2 Andhra Pradesh chief minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy dies in a helicopter crash.

Oct 5 India ranked 134 out of 182 countries in the 2009 Human Development Report.

Oct 22 CBI raids Department of Telecom to probe alleged irregularities in the award of spectrum licences.

Nov 8 The Dalai Lama arrives in Arunachal Pradesh.

Nov 9 MNS members attack Samajwadi Party member Abu Azmi in the Assembly for taking oath in Hindi.

Nov 15 Probe into suspected links of David Coleman Headley in connection with 26/11.

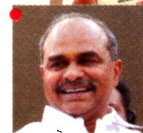
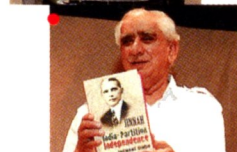
Nov 15 Sachin Tendulkar completes 20 years in international cricket.

Nov 25 President Pratibha Patil, 74, takes flight in a Sukhoi 30 MKI supersonic jet.

Nov 30 Former Jharkhand chief minister Madhu Koda arrested in Rs 2,000-crore scam.

Dec 11 Centre agrees on a separate Telangana state to be carved out of Andhra Pradesh.

Dec 17 L.K. Advani steps down, Sushma Swaraj is the Leader of Opposition and Nitin Gadkari new BJP chief.



new and dangerous level, prompting the prime minister to brand them as "the country's biggest security threat". Better armed, trained, motivated and infinitely more brutalised—demonstrated by the beheading of a security official—the Red Peril underlined the dangers of ignoring socio-political and developmental problems for too long. Fortunately, the man in charge of countering the threat, Home Minister P. Chidambaram, unlike his predecessor, has largely inspired confidence. He admits that 'luck' has played a major role in there being no terror attacks in 2009 but there is no question that his I-mean-business working style and un-bureaucratic approach to the job has contributed in no small measure.

Indeed, India's struggle to overcome its image of being a soft state was best illustrated by its dealings with Pakistan and China. The sustained diplomatic pressure on Pakistan following 26/11 and rejection of talks did impact. Arrests of terror suspects and masterminds may have been a bit of a sham but the very act of a judicial process was admission enough by Islamabad that they were desperate to avoid being isolated and embarrassed any further. China was a different story, overly aggressive even hostile in provoking Delhi at every opportunity but for once, Delhi retaliated in no small measure, best exemplified by the Dalai Lama's visit to Arunachal Pradesh. Yet, as the diplomatic cliché goes, there are no permanent enemies or friends, and by the time Copenhagen came around, the climate had changed, with Beijing and Delhi displaying as much a degree of warmth as the planet under discordant discussion. The growing economic and political clout of the two Asian giants is changing the traditional axis of global power and 2009 could well be a defining moment in world history.

THE GROWING ECONOMIC AND POLITICAL CLOUT OF THE TWO ASIAN GIANTS IS

evident in their presence at global high tables. It is changing the traditional axis of global power and may signify a defining moment in world history.

It was a year when defining moments were in abundance. The Telangana coup in Andhra Pradesh set the stage for a redrawing of state boundaries and, inevitably, smaller, more manageable states. In far-off Chicago, US, the chilling details emanating from the trial of David Coleman Headley and his key role in the 26/11 conspiracy will redefine India's security strategy and perhaps, lead to greater intelligence cooperation in the global war on terror. The rise and rise of the Congress and the decline of the Opposition has significant implications.

The most crucial defining moment was the 2009 General Election when 714 million Indians opted for stability over sentiment in the middle of a drought, a daunting price rise of essential foods and a global economic crisis. It was as hopeful a moment one could hope to get in the context of the road ahead. Oh yes, there was another defining moment. A diminutive 74-year-old woman, Pratibha Patil, President of the Republic, swapping her sari for a flight suit and being strapped into the cockpit of a supersonic fighter jet. As an allegorical emblem of brand India 2009, nothing else came close.